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ISRAEL STRIKES HAMAS IN QATAR

■ UAE CONDEMNS STRIKES IN DOHA AS ‘TREACHEROUS ISRAELI ATTACK’ ■ SAUDI ARABIA CALLS IT ‘CRIMINAL ACT’ VIOLATING INTERNATIONAL NORMS ■ WASHINGTON SAYS IT WAS NOTIFIED BY ISRAEL BEFORE LAUNCHING ATTACK

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N R
Senior Associate Editor

Israel yesterday launched airstrikes targeting Hamas leaders in Qatar, a stunning escalation that threatens to derail Gaza ceasefire talks aimed at ending the war and securing hostage releases. Qatar — which hosts thousands of US troops and has long served as a key mediator between Israel and Hamas — condemned the strikes as a “flagrant violation of all international laws and norms” after smoke rose over its capital, Doha. A Hamas official in Gaza told AFP the group’s negotiators had been “targeted” in Doha, though there was no immediate confirmation of casualties. Qatar’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs said the strikes targeted residential buildings housing several members of Hamas’s political bureau. The ministry described it as a “cowardly Israeli attack” and warned it “will not tolerate this reckless Israeli



Smoke billows after explosions in Qatar’s capital Doha yesterday following air strikes by Israeli military in an operation targeting senior leaders of Palestinian militant group Hamas.

behaviour and the ongoing disruption of regional security.” Spokesperson Majed Al Ansari added that the assault was a “serious threat to the security and safety of Qataris and residents in Qatar.”

The other Gulf states also condemned the attack. Shaikh Abdullah Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs, reaffirmed the UAE’s support for Qatar yesterday following

the Israeli strikes in Doha that targeted a Hamas delegation gathered to discuss a proposed ceasefire plan from the US President. Dr Anwar Gargash, diplomatic adviser to the UAE President,

said the “security of Gulf states is indivisible,” calling the strikes a “treacherous Israeli attack.” **UAE’s solidarity with Qatar** He added: “We stand wholeheartedly with Qatar, condemning the assault and reaffirming our complete solidarity in confronting this aggression. May God protect Qatar, its leadership and people, and safeguard all the Gulf states.” Saudi Crown Prince Mohammad Bin Salman held a phone call with the Emir of Qatar, condemning the strikes as a “criminal act” and a “blatant violation of international law and norms.” He reaffirmed Saudi Arabia’s “full support” for Qatar. The Sultan of Oman has described the strikes as “a blatant breach of sovereignty”. Kuwait’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs denounced the strikes as a “flagrant violation of international law” and urged the UN Security Council to take “decisive action” to halt systematic Israeli aggression in the region. A White House official told

AFP that Israel had informed Washington before launching the strikes in Doha. Qatar is home to Al Udeid Air Base, the largest US military facility in the Middle East and the forward headquarters of US Central Command. The strikes comes as Hamas negotiators in Doha were considering a new ceasefire proposal presented by US President Donald Trump’s envoy. Hamas has described the plan as a “humiliating surrender document” but said it would respond after internal consultations. **SEE ALSO P10 FOR UPDATES AND LATEST NEWS, GO TO GULFNEWS.COM**

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